



AS INDIA DOES NOT ALLOW DUAL CITIZENSHIP, FORMER AUSTRALIA INTERNATIONAL RYAN WILLIAMS (NO. 10) GAVE UP HIS AUSTRALIAN PASSPORT TO PLAY FOR THE BLUE TIGERS

Against five-time champion Brazil in this tournament, the Atlas Lions played the last 25 minutes without a single player born in Morocco. In the quarterfinals, they faced France, whose midfield architect Michael Olise grew up in England and chose to represent Les Bleus through lineage, helping them reach the semifinals with five assists.

Qatar, on the other hand, has relied heavily on naturalisation, with 14 of its 26 World Cup players born outside the country. The AFC Asian Cup champion earned a point and scored against Bosnia and Herzegovina after qualifying for the World Cup on merit for the first time.

India, meanwhile, has taken tentative steps in this direction. Former Australia under-23 international Ryan Williams joined

the Blue Tigers last year after giving up his Australian passport.

The impact was immediate. He scored on his debut to help India beat Hong Kong 2-1 in the AFC Asian Cup qualifiers, securing its first qualifying win in 15 months.

The All India Football Federation (AIFF) has also been in discussions with the Sports Ministry over a special Sports Passport that would allow Overseas Citizens of India or Persons of Indian Origin (OCIs/PIOs) to represent the senior national team.

However, India may be functioning on borrowed time as

other Asian nations continue to progress rapidly.

Uzbekistan and Jordan made their World Cup debuts, Iraq returned to the tournament after a 40-year absence, and Iran narrowly missed reaching the round of 32.

For decades, the World Cup has stood as a beacon of unity and sportsmanship. With immigrants taking centre stage in the 2026 edition, it reminded us once again that when the ball starts rolling, what matters is who scores, not where they come from.